Family Strain and the Desire to be 'Good Men' among Juvenile Offenders

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Pictures provided by Google images

INTRODUCTION

This project explores the transition of young men from juvenile residential correctional facilities back into communities and examines what types of support are necessary in aiding successful transitions. More specifically, we analyze the effects of familial relation on the transition process. Unlike young adults from middle and upper-middle class families, individuals in our study are all from poor or working class families and do not receive significant financial, social, and cultural resources from parents or guardians.

Young adults from lower income categories are responsible for providing for parents, siblings, and children. With this responsibility comes a deep desire to provide for their loved ones and stands as a motivation to find legitimate work, go back to school, and avoid returning to serious crime. This desire to be a "good man" is a strong psychological and emotional factor that aids the transition process.

METHOD

Participants:
Two criteria for selecting the young, male participants for this study: 1) they had to be 18 years or older, and 2) must be approximately 30 days away from their release from the correctional facility at the time of the first interview.

Basic Characteristics:
- Of the four participants, three are African American males and one is of Eastern European descent.
- Three of the four participants were raised without fathers.
- Three of the four participants are fathers.
- All participants are from urban areas.
- All were released from a private, non-profit correctional facility.
- All of the crimes committed prior to incarceration were related to robbery or drug dealing.

Method:
- Conducted one pre-exit interview with each young man and three post-exit interviews at 3, 9, and 18 months after being released. After this schedule of interviewing, we still collected interviews whenever the men had time.
- The length of the open ended interviews varied between a half hour and an hour.
- We coded the interviews to analyze family support during the transition process. We divided the coding groups were divided into: material and emotional support; material and emotional strain. In addition, material support was broken into sub-categories of financial resources, employment resources, educational resources, transportation support, housing support and the same corresponding strains.

RESEARCH QUESTIONS

- Is family support important to achieving success during the transition from juvenile correctional facility back into communities?
- If so, what type of familial support aids in a successful transition from juvenile correctional facility back into communities?

Quotes

"I'm gunna do what I got to do to [follow] probation...to stay out, to see money, to get money, to focus on my family…"

"I'm looking forward to being there for my daughter more and going to school and getting better education than I've got, pursuing something with my life or something like that."

"Now that I came out young , I have a family, I'll have a baby, everything like that, finishing college, making good money, that's something you look forward to, not something you want to mess up."



BACKGROUND

Family support has become more common in the lives of young adults. According to a recent study, "[seventy-five] percent of the young adults in a national sample still receive financial help from their parents (Siennick, 2011). In an era when it takes several years and credentials to secure a well-paying job, parents' support makes it possible for young adults to seek those credentials and to meet the rising costs of living" (2011). Parents with more resources are able to provide more to their adult children and can thus bridge them into more advantageous positions in society during this phase (Swartz, 2008).

Social learning theorists also argue that parental management encourages self-control, which in turn reduces the likelihood of delinquent behavior. (Ryan & Yang, 2005). Researchers have repeatedly linked several family-related factors to delinquent behaviors, including: "coercive parenting, strained parent–child relationships, inconsistent discipline, neglect, parental substance abuse, violence, sexual abuse, attachment disruption, and inadequate levels of warmth and affection" (Abrams and Synder, 2010). This can be further explored by studying the affect of family-related factors as deterrence from delinquent behaviors after incarceration.

FINDINGS

Successful Transition

For the purpose of this study, a successful transition is defined as reentering into the community and becoming stable, independent, productive members of society.

Factors Found Necessary For Successful Transitions:
- Had resources (family or other) for times of financial need
- Had resources (family or other) for housing when needed
- Received consistent encouragement towards becoming 'good men' from family
- Viewed family as a form of motivation to becoming 'good men' and staying away from crime
- Desire to provide for family created motivation to become 'good men'

Material Support	Emotional Support
Financial	Encouragement
Housing	Motivation

DISCUSSION

- The definition of family varies for each of these participants. Mom and siblings, extended family, and girlfriend's family are all different forms of family for these participants.
- While making the transition back into the community, being able to rely on family for housing provided time to find employment and then look for independent housing.
- Having a family that was willing and able to financially support the participants, when necessary, provided a strong foundation for a successful transition.
- Without financial support from family, participants were responsible for providing financial support to their families, which added stress to their achievement of independent financial stability.
- Without family housing support, participants were forced to find and maintain independent living. If unable to find housing, participants were left homeless.
- Continuous encouragement from family provided participants with affirmation that they could become 'good men.'
- Viewing family as a source of motivation helped participants to stay on the right track and work to become the 'good men' they wanted to be.
- When participants' families were stable and self sufficient, the participants were able to focus on their goals and rely on their families as resources when necessary.
- When participants' families were unstable and struggling, they were unable to focus on achieving their goals. They focused on their families' issues and instability before themselves.
- For future research, I suggest a comparison of the family support received by low-income and middle-class juvenile delinquents.

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